



AN ORIGINAL STORY IN THREE LIGHTS

The Lantern of Asteria

Written for the evening walkers and the small brave creatures beside them.

CHAPTER ONE



The city above the clouds

Every map in Asteria began with a light. Nia carried hers in a brass lantern that had belonged to her grandmother, though no one could explain why its flame never leaned in the wind.

At dawn, the lantern pointed upward. Nia followed its glow across the last bridge of the village, with Pip the fox padding at her side, until the clouds opened and revealed a city of white towers drifting in the sky.



The compass that remembered

In the observatory, Nia found a compass with no needle. Its silver face held a reflection of the moon, and the lantern showed her the missing path in a line of gold across the floor.

The path led down to a lake beneath the city. Nia placed the lantern beside an old stone compass and waited. Pip curled beside her. When the stars appeared in the water, the compass began to turn.

THE LAST LIGHT

A map for going home

The compass did not point north. It pointed to every place where someone was waiting to be found. Nia understood then that the lantern had never been asking her to leave home. It had been teaching her how to return.

She drew the route from the village to the clouds and from the clouds to the lake. Pip added one paw print in the corner. Together they carried the map back before breakfast.

That evening, the villagers lit their windows one by one. High above them, the floating city answered with a constellation of its own.

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